

green and blue pixels via a wire mesh darkens the pixels and thus, prevents the backlight from showing through.

In Plasma screens, a network of pixels—each comprising red, green and blue phosphors—is mounted between two thin glass layers. Small electrical pulses excite the rare natural gases argon, neon and xenon to produce colour information and light. Once the phosphors are excited, oxygen atoms dissipate and emit ultra-violet light.

LCD TVs are thinner and lighter, but offer limited viewing angles. However, unlike Plasma displays, they consume lesser power and do not suffer from screen burn-in effects.

A viable option is the multi-function display, which functions as a PC monitor and a TV as well. Samsung, LG and Philips offer you a

Opt for a projector to create a theatrical ambience

conductor called Digital Micromirror Device (DMD) that comprises over a million microscopic mirrors that move back and forth around 5000 times per second. Working in conjunction with a lamp, colour wheel and projections lens, they reflect a digital image onto a screen. As compared to LCD, DLP technology is rated to be better as it provides higher contrast, sharper images, better motion reproduction, and consistent image quality.

While buying a projector, pay attention to the brightness and the image quality offered. Brightness is measured in ANSI lumens. For home theatre projectors, this typically ranges from 700 to 2,000 lumens. Use higher brightness projectors when the ambient light in the room is more than adequate. Rooms with controlled lighting require lower brightness projectors. As for image quality, look at resolution and brightness uniformity.

Look for an XGA or WXGA resolution projector with a uniformity rating of around 85 per cent. Canon, Epson, and HP have models catering to the home segment. In fact, HP's new ep9012 features an integrated DVD player, a subwoofer and 2.1 surround sound. You can play DVDs straight from the projector, with support for DVD±R/RW, VCD, SVCD, CD-R/RW, CD-audio and MP3 playback. The ep9012 is not yet available in India, but is expected to be introduced soon. Price? Hmm, good question! We await HP's answer to that!



The Creative Inspire T7700

number of options in this segment. Samsung has a 15-inch LCD TV model priced around Rs 35,000, while 17-inch models start from Rs 60,000. The 17-inch model from Samsung is also HDTV-ready, making it future-proof.

Speakers

A good speaker set should blast off sound that fills your senses and overwhelms you—be it music, movies, or games. Though stereo and even 2.1 speakers should be fine for standard usage, opt for a 4.1 and above for a complete sound experience. Do make sure you get the speaker placement right, so that you have true surround effect. Choose from premium brands such as Creative, Altec Lansing, Logitech and Philips, to Indian brands such as Frontech, Intex, Odyssey etc.

While a decent 4.1 speaker system costs anywhere between Rs 2,000 to Rs 3,500, do expect to shell out around Rs 3,000 to Rs 20,000 for a 5.1 set. Then there are the 6.1 and 7.1 speaker systems for the true audiophile. Creative is the most popular brand here: opt for their Inspire range if affordability is your concern, and the MegaWorks range if you do not want to settle for anything less than high-class sound quality.

Home Projectors

LCD and Digital Light Processing (DLP) projectors have been around for a while now and served dutifully in corporate environments, boardrooms and at presentations. However, decreasing prices and reduced sizes make them worthwhile for use in a home theatre setup.

DLP projectors use a thumbnail-sized semi-

Home Theatre Systems

While a PC-based setup may offer you a lot of flexibility as far as entertainment choices are concerned, a home theatre system can also be a good option. Home theatres have been around for ages. The big brands here include Sony, Samsung, Philips, and LG. In case you do not have decent speakers and a big display, you can hook up your PC to a home theatre system and your existing TV and play music and movies on the PC.

Apart from the cost, do remember to consider the video and audio formats (most support MP3 playback) supported by the home theatre, along with the type of media. The Philips DVD/SACD Home Theatre System LX3900SA supports a variety of formats including Divx, MPEG4, MP3 and Picture CD. Supported media includes DVD±RW, DVD±R, CD-R, CD-RW, and SACD Multichannel. ☒

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Philips MX 5700D - DVD Systems